

The Basics of Hume's Epistemology

1. Introduction

David Hume (1711-1776) arrived on the philosophical scene at a time when what is known today as empiricism was at its peak, following the likes of Bacon, Gassendi, Locke and Berkeley, among other figures. Like many thinkers of his time, Hume too argued that it was experience that was the legitimate and ultimate basis for knowledge concerning the world. It is this positioning of the primacy of experience over pure reason that makes Hume fall in the camp of the empiricists.

Now, an important influence of Newtonian mechanics on philosophy was the mode in which philosophers thought of the mind and its contents. Philosophers of the seventeenth and eighteenth centuries largely operated with the idea that it was possible to chart out the mind and its contents as a mechanical system, much along the lines of Newtonian mechanics. In other words, it was a thriving belief that the mode in which the mind operated could be elucidated in terms of a basic category of the fundamental unit of the contents of the mind, like the category of 'idea' along with the specific laws that governed the ways in which the mind could operate upon these ideas, leading to the generation of the whole edifice of knowledge. Thus, much like his predecessors and his contemporaries, Hume's epistemology implicitly operates with the assumption that it is possible to chart out a mechanical theory of the mind that could lay bare our nature as knowing beings. Hence, by and large, Hume's epistemology is coloured by shades of what would today be considered as psychology. Hume is explicit in his 'Introduction' to his work, *A Treatise of Human Nature: Being an Attempt to Introduce the Experimental Method of Reasoning into Moral Subjects* (henceforth *Treatise*), that an inquiry into the 'science of man' which for him is an inquiry into the nature of the mind and the modes of its operations or 'powers of the mind' is a prerequisite for all other sciences, since it is the mind with its operations, after all, that is the source of all other sciences or of knowledge itself. The *Treatise* is, therefore, conceived by Hume as a work explicating human nature. Following Locke's epistemological approach of first analyzing and categorizing the contents of the mind in order to lay out the nature and the limits of human understanding, Hume too begins his *Treatise* with a classification of the contents of the mind.

2. Hume's Division of Perceptions

Unlike Locke, who regarded 'ideas' as the fundamental unit of the contents of our minds, for Hume, the fundamental units of the mind were 'perceptions'.¹ Within the Humean epistemology, the term 'perception' is a generic term that is employed by Hume to denote the content of our mind, including what we may call sensations, mental images, feelings, emotions, thoughts and ideas. Hume then goes on to divide perceptions into two kinds, *impressions* and *ideas*. This Humean division of the contents of the mind into impressions and ideas is deeply rooted in Hume's Realism. Like Locke, and in contrast to Berkeley, Hume maintained that the external world, both physical and social, existed independently of any mind. It is important to note here that since Hume firmly adhered to the thesis of Realism, the division of perceptions into impressions and ideas was taken by him as something that was intuitively clear, and as something that did not demand much clarification. For Hume, of the two kinds of perceptions that we are conscious of, 'impressions' are those perceptions that can be said to be the awareness that comes through our direct experiences, such as the experience provided to us by our senses.

¹ A major influence on Hume's thoughts was the works of Francis Hutcheson. Hutcheson's influence shaped Hume's own thoughts on passions and morals. The term 'perception' was borrowed by Hume from Hutcheson, who used it, following Descartes, to denote the contents of the mind in place of the Lockean term 'ideas' which was confusing given Plato's usage of the term.

But what is peculiar to Hume is that for him, impressions also include experiences of bodily pain and pleasure and feelings of aversion and the like. In other words, for Hume, impressions are awareness brought about by experiences that are not mediated by reason or any conscious reflective operations of the mind. According to Hume, it is by operating upon these impressions that the mind manages to generate the second category of perceptions, namely, *ideas*, and consequently builds the entire edifice of knowledge. *Ideas* for Hume constitute those of our perceptions that are images of the *impressions* generated by the mind when we think about or recollect the original impressions that we have had. Hence, ideas, in contrast to impressions, are perceptions of the mind that are images of impressions we have had in the past. Hume holds that there are two modes in which ideas may be generated through impressions. They could either be recollected through the *faculty of memory*, in which case the idea or the recollected image is more closely aligned to the original impression, or they could be generated through the *faculty of imagination*, in which case we employ other powers of the mind to generate fresh ideas from previous impressions or ideas recollected through memory. We shall say more on this later in this section.

Now, Hume upholds the division between impressions, or perceptions that are passively received by the mind, and ideas, which are, in contrast, perceptions that are images of those impressions. The characteristic mark that distinguishes an impression from its idea is described by Hume in terms of the *vividness* and *force* with which it appears in our consciousness. That is, Hume regards impressions as being clearer and more vivid than ideas, which are but images of those impressions. This is why Hume regards the division of perceptions into impressions and ideas as being intuitively clear: an image can never be more vivid or forceful upon the mind than that of which it is an image.

Given this analysis of the contents of the mind, it is clear that within the Humean epistemological framework, the foundation of all our knowledge ultimately rests on impressions, which can be seen as the fundamental building blocks of our entire edifice of knowledge. In the same light, it also becomes evident that within Humean epistemology, impressions also set the limits to our understanding in terms of what can be known by us with certainty. Given that for Hume, the foundational ground of all our knowledge consists of impressions, therefore any knowledge claim that cannot be analyzed ultimately in terms of impressions would have to be cast out from the domain of the knowable.

Now, as a Realist, Hume contends that the source of impressions is external to the mind, though given his strict adherence to the principle of empiricism, he regards these impressions as *arising from unknown causes*²

In his *Treatise*, immediately after dividing perceptions into impressions and ideas, Hume goes on to provide us a second division of perceptions into *simple* perceptions and *complex* perceptions. Thus, in conjunction with the first division of perceptions into impressions and ideas, we now have simple perceptions of impressions, or *simple impressions*, and simple perceptions of ideas or *simple ideas*. Likewise, we have complex perceptions of impressions or *complex impressions*, and complex perceptions of ideas or *complex ideas*. For Hume, seeing the colour red would give me a simple impression of red, while recollecting it later in its absence, say, in the dark, would bring forth a simple idea of red. Similarly,

² Hume's epistemological framework positions *'impressions'* as the ultimate building blocks of knowledge. This has far-reaching metaphysical consequences, which includes the possibility of asserting with certainty any substantial notion of the self or of matter or *substratum*. Hume's epistemological position is put forth in his thesis that any idea that fails to be grounded on impressions has to be cast aside. It must however be noted that this does not in any clear fashion entail the ontological thesis of denying the existence of matter. What Hume's epistemological position denies is merely the possibility of making any certain claims about them. Hume's adherence to Realism is clear when he holds, for instance, in Book I, Part IV, Section II of his *Treatise*, that the belief in the independent, continued existence of external body is something that *'we must take for granted in all our reasonings'*. Thus, for Hume, the most fundamental question that one can at best raise pertaining to the existence of an independent external world is about the causes that lead us to believe in the existence of such a world.

seeing a house would generate in me a complex impression of a house, while thinking about it later would generate a complex idea of a house.

This further division of perceptions into *simple* and *complex* is important within Hume's epistemological framework, since Hume holds that every simple impression has a simple idea³ that accurately corresponds to it; more importantly, every simple idea has a corresponding simple impression where it finds its origin.⁴ In other words, Hume's thesis entails that we cannot have a single simple idea prior to, or without first having had, its corresponding impression. However, Hume holds that such a relation of accurate correspondence does not *necessarily* obtain between a complex idea and a complex impression. I may, for instance see a street in Delhi and be aware of the various sounds as I walk down it and have an immediate complex impression of a Delhi street, and I might, through some skilled practice, recollect every little detail about it later and thus have an accurately corresponding complex idea of a Delhi street. It is, however, more likely that on recollecting the complex impression I might miss out on the little details and thus have a complex idea that is not an exact copy of my original impression⁵ of the Delhi street. Furthermore, I might completely imagine a complex idea of the Delhi street even without having been there at all, by simply bringing together other impressions like the simple impressions of various colours, or complex impressions of houses I might have seen in some other places. I might, in other words, *imagine* a complex idea of a Delhi street even without having a corresponding complex impression of a Delhi street. However, Hume argues that even such an imaginative enterprise must ultimately be rooted in other simple impressions, or complex impressions which can be broken down into simple impressions, or in ideas which are themselves based on simple impressions. Thus, within Hume's epistemological framework, our imagination and creativity are ultimately confined and limited by our simple impressions, which are the fundamental blocks through which we erect our edifice of knowledge. Hume takes this primacy of simple impressions as being evident from the fact that the deaf can never ever have an idea of a 'sound' or the blind of colours, which reinforces his fundamental belief that every idea necessarily emerges from simple impressions, though we may have a complex idea that has no corresponding complex impression. Hume holds that our *faculty of imagination*, through the operation of the powers of the mind i like *compounding*, that is, bringing together two or more ideas additively; *transposing*, that is, projecting aspects of one idea upon another;⁶ *augmenting*;⁷ and *diminishing*⁸ i

³ It must be kept in mind that though Hume uses the terms 'resembles' and 'corresponds' in talking about the relation between a simple impression and its corresponding simple idea, they nevertheless cannot be identical given that ideas, for Hume, will always lack the 'force and vitality' of an impression. This becomes clearer if we look at the relation between complex ideas and complex impressions.

⁴ It is this belief that leads Hume to assert that all our knowledge about the external world must ultimately be based on simple impressions. However, it is interesting to note that Hume in his *Treatise* also provides us with a counter-example that could prove his thesis wrong. Hume himself argues that it is possible for someone who has had all the impressions, and thereby has all the corresponding ideas, of the various shades of blue, save one, to generate the simple idea of that shade of blue without first having had a corresponding impression of it. However, he argues that this one instance 'does not merit that, for it alone, we should alter our general maxim'

⁵ This point may be elucidated by the simple fact that, while recollecting a place that we have visited, we seldom recollect the sounds and the smells. Of course, even if there were no sounds and smells in the original instance of having the complex impression which was, say, provided to me only by sight, I might still miss out on the smaller details of the original impression in my complex idea.

⁶ Say, we take the idea of 'edible' and combine it with the idea of a 'house', resulting in the idea of an 'edible house'

⁷ For instance, when we take an idea of the colour 'light red' and conceptually enhance its redness till we generate the idea of 'dark red' This power is of some importance since it explains how we get ideas of 'perfect x' when all that we have had is an impression of 'x'

enables us to generate a whole gamut of ideas, both simple and complex. But it is this very power of generating ideas from simple impressions that is the root cause of concern for Hume, for it leads us to make nonsensical claims. Further, it also entails that the more we deploy the powers of the mind upon an impression or an idea, the further we move away from the originary impression upon which the idea was originally grounded, and thus enhance the possibility of conflating and confusing it with other ideas. This is what, for instance, Hume holds responsible for the nonsensical position that an *abstract idea* is an idea that is distinct from the idea of the particular object of which it is an abstract idea. Hume argues that the very notion of an abstract idea, or the universal idea of an object, though derived from impressions of particular objects, nevertheless comes to be confused and conflated with a distinct idea that has a corresponding impression when there is none. Hume offers to those who are thus confused the therapeutic solution, that they must simply bear in mind the fundamental thesis that not all our ideas entail a corresponding impression.

3. Hume's Further Division of Impressions

So far, Hume classification of impressions has been based on the modes in which impressions come to our mind. But Hume also provides a further division of impressions in terms of their constitutive nature. On this basis, he classifies impressions into two kinds depending on the mode in which they occur in our minds. The first class of impressions he calls *original impressions* or *impressions of sensation*. These are impressions that have no antecedent perceptions from which they can be derived, and that emerge by virtue of the 'constitution of the body' or through the sense organs. Thus, all the impressions that we receive through our senses as well as experiences of pain and pleasure are, for Hume, impressions of sensation. In contrast to these, Hume formulates a second category of impressions, namely, *secondary impressions* or *impressions of reflection*. These impressions are derived from simple ideas that are based on impressions of sensation. Elucidating this division further, Hume holds that upon receiving an impression of sensation like 'heat or cold, thirst or hunger, pleasure or pain' the mind can generate an idea of these impressions, which can in turn generate a further impression of aversion, hope, desire or fear. Now, it must be made clear that impressions of reflection, though based on ideas, are not themselves ideas but are new impressions, since they are not copies or images of any ideas. Thus, secondary impressions, or impressions of reflection, like an experience of love, hate, pride or desire, are not *ideas* but are impressions, though they are dependent upon ideas that can be drawn forth from memory. Thus, I may have actually had a bad experience of the heat while travelling through the Thar Desert, and hence might develop an aversion to any invitation to go to another desert, but the feeling of aversion that I experience is not an *idea* or an image of the impression of pain that I had experienced earlier, though it is based on it. Thus, for Hume, all 'passions' or emotions would fall under the category of secondary impressions or impressions of reflection.

It is this division of impressions into *impressions of sensation* and *impressions of reflection* that enables Hume to flesh out his theory of passions and of morals in the later part of his *Treatise*.

4. Hume on Relating Ideas

Hume is perfectly aware that his epistemological structure has so far only accounted for the variety of the ideas in our mind, but solitary ideas based on our impressions cannot by themselves exhaust the confines of our mind, nor do they, by themselves, constitute knowledge. These simple ideas must be related in a systematic manner so as to provide the possibility of the articulation of a thought that is meaningful and leads to a judgment that can be ascribed a truth value. In other words, knowledge is constituted when

⁸ For example, when we take an idea of the colour 'dark red' and conceptually reduce its redness till we generate the idea of 'light red'

ideas are in a *relation*. Hume's minimalistic approach grants this role of relating our simple ideas to the *faculty of imagination*, which as we have seen earlier is the faculty that operates upon our ideas to generate other ideas. Hume holds that, by and large, the faculty of imagination is guided by three universal principles in its task of relating simple ideas with one another, namely, the *principle of resemblance*, the *principle of contiguity in time and space*, and the *principle of cause and effect*. Hume argues that the universal nature of these principles as the guiding force for the faculty of imagination in relating our simple ideas is highlighted by the fact that a thought in one language can easily be meaningfully translated into another. Such translation would not have been possible, Hume would argue, if the modes in which we related simple ideas were not guided by principles that all minds shared, but were instead based on a completely arbitrary association of our simple ideas. However, we must note that Hume takes these to be universal guiding principles that could be violated by the faculty of imagination so as to relate simple ideas in uncommon ways, as, for instance, in an artistic endeavour.⁹

However, according to Hume, even when ideas, simple or complex, are related in an arbitrary fashion, the relations that are established between these ideas by the free play of our faculty of imagination may be subsumed under seven kinds. These are the *relation of resemblance*, the *relation of identity*, the *relation of space and time* which provides us with spatial and temporal relations like before, far, near, after, here, now, then, there, etc., the *relation of quantity or number*, the *relation of degrees of quality* which provides us with relations of more or less, like heavier, lighter, etc., the *relation of contrariety*, and the *relation of cause and effect*.

For Hume, by virtue of the fact that the principles that guide our faculty of imagination in relating simple ideas to generate complex ones are universal in nature ensure that we share a common picture of the world or, at the least, enable us to share our thoughts about the world meaningfully with others. But then, it immediately occurs to us that not all of these construed relations between ideas can be asserted with an equal degree of certainty. I can, for instance, claim that Raman is the tallest boy in my town, but that does not entail that this is in fact so. Or for instance, the thought that $2 + 2 = 4$ can surely be claimed with much more certainty than the thought that it will be a warm day tomorrow. This leads Hume to consider the nature of the relations between ideas in order to address the issue of the degree of certainty that can be claimed with regard to the truth-value of our assertions of the relations that we draw between our ideas. Though Hume begins to address this issue in Part III of Book I of his *Treatise*, its clearest articulation, commonly known as 'Hume's Fork' is found in Section 4 of his *An Enquiry Concerning Human Understanding*.

5. Hume's Fork

Hume divides thoughts, or the relations that are established between ideas by the faculty of imagination, into two sharp, irreducible divisions. This Humean division of the possible relations between ideas has earned the label 'Hume's Fork' which metaphorically represents the two divisions of thoughts as the two prongs of a fork that can never meet. Hume holds that we can either have thoughts whose certainty depends upon entities in the external world, or we can have thoughts whose certainty does not depend upon entities in the external world. For example, Hume holds that we can know for certain that in some cases of assertions of relation between some ideas like, $2 + 2 = 4$ or that a bachelor is an unmarried man or that in a sentence, if the subject is a singular form, then the sentence demands a verb in the singular form. However, these thoughts do not tell us anything immediately about entities in the external world, nor do they depend upon the latter for their certainty. Such thoughts, Hume holds, can simply be ascertained with certainty, or can be seen to be true by virtue of the very nature of the ideas and the

⁹ Thus, though Hume's universal guiding principles for relating simple ideas may be seen as a precursor of Kant's 'transcendental categories of the understanding' they differ from the latter precisely because Hume's guiding principles, though universal, are not necessarily binding upon the faculty of imagination.

relationship that is established between them. For instance, when I claim that $2 + 2 = 4$ I am relating the ideas of 2 and 4 in a particular way, but the way in which I relate these ideas together along with the nature of the ideas being related are sufficient to ascertain the truth-value of the assertion, that is, whether it is true or false. Such thoughts, for Hume, are thus either intuitively or demonstrably certain. However, at the same time, for Hume, this independence means that such thoughts never assert or entail the existence of a concrete entity corresponding to these ideas. Such thoughts are classified by Hume as knowledge concerning the *relations of ideas*. Though Hume regards geometry and arithmetic as constituting the domains where such thoughts are operative, we could club other formal sciences such as grammar and logic under the class of knowledge that pertains to *relations of ideas*. One may safely assume that all propositions that we would, following Kant, today label as *analytic propositions*¹⁰ would fall under the class of relations of ideas.

On the other hand, we do have thoughts that assert relations between ideas, which at the same time claim that some corresponding state of affairs obtains in the external world. Such thoughts that assert a state of affairs or facts about the external world are classified by Hume as *matters of fact*.

This is not to say that our knowledge of the external world does not consist in relating ideas, for it obviously does! For example, if I say that 'the trees are green' which is a statement about the external world, of course I am relating the ideas of 'tree' and 'green' in a specific way. But that does not make it a piece of knowledge classified under *relations of ideas*, since the way in which I relate the ideas of 'tree' and 'green' is not sufficient to establish the truth-value of the statement, for it asserts or entails the existence of something corresponding to the ideas out in the world. In the case of my claim of the trees being green, I must take recourse to experience (impressions) to verify if the trees are *in fact* green. In other words, I must verify, by taking recourse to my experience or impressions, that the relation that is postulated between the ideas of 'tree' and 'green' in the thought in fact holds in the external world. Thus, in contrast to thoughts that belong to the category of relations of ideas, thoughts that concern matters of fact are neither intuitively nor demonstrably certain. This, Hume argues, is clear enough from the fact that we can easily conceive a perfectly intelligible fact contrary to the asserted thought without involving a contradiction. Thus, if I can assert that 'the sun will rise tomorrow' I can as well assert, with equal intelligibility, the contrary thought that 'the sun will not rise tomorrow' and it would be impossible for us to judge, based solely on the thoughts themselves, as to which of these assertions actually hold without taking recourse to something outside the domain of ideas, namely by taking recourse to our impressions or experience. Furthermore, according to Hume, this highlights the fact that thoughts that pertain to the class of matters of fact engage with ideas that either assert or imply the existence of entities that correspond to those ideas.

Within Hume's epistemological framework, the classification of thoughts into matters of fact and relations of ideas is, in fact, an exhaustive classification. In other words, for Hume, a legitimate thought is an assertion that is either about concrete entities whose certainty is dependent upon the verification of the correspondence between our impressions and the ideas constituting the thought, or one that is about abstract ideas that have no bearing, and are not dependent, upon the existence or non-existence of any concrete entity in the external world. Thus, if a thought conforms to neither of these categories, for instance, the thought 'God exists' or 'the soul is immortal' it must be completely discarded as nonsense or must be set to be 'consumed by the flames' if we are to use Hume's words!

¹⁰ Briefly stated, these are propositions that do not require the mediation of our experience in the ascertainment of their truth-value.

6. The Limits of Assertions of Matters of Fact

The epistemological framework upheld by Hume thus firmly establishes that the certainty of our thoughts about the external world, expressed through our assertions of 'matters of fact' must be ultimately validated by experience.¹¹ However, this claim of Hume would entail that *not all* our assertions about the external world can attain absolute certainty. This is because our impressions are always confined to *specific, singular* experiences. In other words, our experiences, which are the ultimate source of the ideas constituting a thought about an entity in the world, furnish us only with impressions that are bound within a specific space (here) and a specific time (now). Thus, within Hume's epistemological framework, our impressions are essentially bound by the temporal and spatial confines of the 'here and now' (the present). They can, at best, be extended to ideas that are recollected through the faculty of memory, but the mind is nevertheless incapable of accessing the dimensions of space and time that is *not yet*, that is, it has no access to impressions of the future. Hence, experience can only legitimize those knowledge claims as *certainly true* or *certainly false* that are confined within the temporality of the present, and derivatively of the past. Thus, our assertions of matters of fact cannot justify claims that extend beyond the temporality of the past and the present, for we would have no way of accessing their certainty in the absence of corresponding impressions of the future.

Hence, knowledge claims about the external world, like 'the sun shall rise tomorrow' or 'water boils at 100 degrees Celsius' cannot be certified to be absolutely certain on the basis of our experience.

Based on this line of argumentation, Hume concludes that experience can at best verify with absolute certainty that 'water, so far, has always boiled at 100 degrees Celsius' or that 'this pot of water boiled at 100 degrees Celsius' or 'the sun has so far always risen' or 'the sun rose today' since we do have corresponding experience to verify and ascertain the truths of these claims by virtue of present impressions as well as those of the past. But to claim with absolute certainty that 'water boils at 100 degrees Celsius' would require us to have an impossible experience, that is, to experience today, the boiling of water that is to boil tomorrow. In other words, it demands that I should have access to experiences of 'all' cases of water boiling, while it remains a fact, given the *limits of experiencibility*, that at best I can have access only to cases of water boiling in the past and in the present, but not future cases of water boiling.

Thus, Hume argues, given the limits of spatiality and temporality within which impressions are possible, we can never have absolute certainty about thoughts that involve ideas that are yet to have corresponding impressions, though we might have had present and past impressions corresponding to those ideas. In other words, Hume argues that generic universal statements involving 'all' (universal affirmative of the form 'all S is P') or involving 'no' (universal negative of the form 'no S is P'), about the external world can never be absolutely certified on the basis of experience. Given the limits of experiencibility, we can at best have absolute certainty only on those statements about the external world that confine themselves to specific singular or a set of such specific singular experiences of the form 'some S is P' (particular affirmative) or 'some S is not P' (particular negative).

Thus, according to Hume, though it is correct to hold experience as the legitimate source of knowledge about the external world, or as the basis for knowledge pertaining to matters of fact, we must nevertheless also realize the limits of experiencibility, and thereby acknowledge that we can never have absolute certainty about the external world as expressed by our generic universal statements about it. For Hume, to assert otherwise would be to push the limits of experiencibility so far as to land ourselves in the domain of the fallacy of deriving 'all' from 'some'.¹²

¹¹ This is why Hume is also considered as the precursor of the Logical Positivists.

¹² It is this conclusion of Hume that allows certain scholars to label him as a 'mitigated sceptic'. This implies that Hume was not a thorough sceptic, since he does not absolutely deny the possibility of knowledge as such. For Hume, knowledge is possible in within the realm of the relation of. Hume's

7. The Principle of Custom or Habit

We must note here that Hume acknowledges the fact that we however, do make such claims, as well as believe them to be absolutely certain. For instance, based on our previous experiences, we genuinely believe and assert thoughts like ‘the sun will rise tomorrow’ and we are also genuinely certain that it will. Thus, even if we agree with Hume that we are surely mistaken in making such assertions and assigning them absolute certainty, Hume must still show the source of these thoughts that somehow manage to go beyond the impressions provided by my senses (in the present) and the ideas provided by my memory (from the past).¹³ Hume argues that it is the relation of cause and effect, in collusion with the ‘principle of custom or habit’ that allows for such general assertions to move beyond the evidence provided to us by our senses and our faculty of memory.

Hume argues that our belief in the certainty of generic assertions is merely a case of a subjective assurance (an assurance which I give to myself). However by this, Hume does not mean that I deceive myself by consciously assuring myself of the certainty of such an assertion. In fact, Hume holds that this act of assurance is not ‘impelled by any reasoning or process of understanding’ but is rather akin to an act performed out of habit or custom, just as one may bite one’s nails out of habit without being aware of biting one’s nails. Hume holds that when an impression is constantly followed by another impression in a sequence, the mind’s *power of association*, out of habit, conjoins the ideas of these impressions in a relation of *cause and effect*, thus leading us to believe in the existence of a *necessary* relation between two ideas, though we lack any impression that could support this necessity. In other words, Hume holds that this habit of translating constantly recurring sequences of impressions into a necessary relation of cause and effect is ‘a principle of human nature’ though on analysis we realize that the relation that we claim as necessary is nothing more than a result of *customary conjunctions*, or cases of *constant conjunction* that are devoid of any objective basis.

In other words, Hume seeks to distinguish the fact that we *believe* such generic statements to be true, from the fact that they are *in fact* true independent of whether we believe them as true or not. That is to say, Hume argues that though I may believe that my generic statements concerning matters of fact are true, it does not entail with any certainty that they are in fact true, since I have no corresponding experience to verify my generic statements, because these statements demand experience of the future as well – that is, experiences that I have not yet had. Thus, for Hume, though my experiences are confined to impressions of *some* – as a fact of natural habit I make generic statements about *all* –

Further, Hume views this natural habit that grounds our belief in the relation of *cause and effect* not merely as the basis for our generic assertions about the natural world, but also as the grounds for many of the beliefs we hold pertaining to our social world – for instance, the belief that someone will keep her promise based on one’s experience that she has in fact always kept her promises in the past.

epistemology also theoretically allows for the possibility of knowledge pertaining to matters of fact as long as they are confined within the limits of experiencibility. Nevertheless, Hume denies the possibility of knowledge concerning matters of fact that involve generic and universal statements about the world (expressed by assertions in the form of universal affirmative or negative propositions).

¹³ Hume addresses this issue concretely in Part III of Book I of his *Treatise*, but more lucidly in Sections 4 and 5 of his *Enquiry*.